Lesson 19

Money/Riches

"Keep your lives free from the love of money and
be content with what you have."
(Hebrews 13:5)

Money: the unit of currency used to purchase
or exchange goods or services

Some people love money and spend their whole lives focused on acquiring material things. In the Bible, God repeatedly warns against this approach to life. It is "ok" to have money, as long as money does not have you. Turn to God's word to find the proper balance and perspective on money and riches.

Synopsis

God warns Christians to keep their lives free from the love of money and to be content with whatever they have.[1] The scriptures advise that people who run around trying to get rich are often led into foolish and harmful desires, which ultimately plunge them into ruin and destruction.[2] In a curious paradox, God points out that people who love money never seem to have enough[3]—they always seem to want "just a little more."

Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content
with what you have, because God has said,
"Never will I leave you; never will I forsake you."
(Hebrews 13:5)[1]

People who want to get rich fall into temptation and
a trap and into many foolish and harmful desires
that plunge men into ruin and destruction.
(1 Timothy 6:10)[2]

People with money and riches can also develop a false sense of security. They imagine their money to be a "fortified city," and that they are safe behind its walls.[4] However, God can see behind the wall to view our true selves. And when He looks behind the wall at the rich man, He often sees a person who is "wretched, pitiful, poor, blind and naked."[5]

Not only can God see behind the wall, He can also see the ironic folly of building up treasures on earth. After a lifetime of "heaping up wealth," the rich man dies and does not take anything with him after death.[6] He came into the world naked, and he leaves naked.[7]

If you are fortunate enough to accumulate wealth, do not set your heart on it.[8] Keep in mind, that as soon as you start focusing on making money, you can lose everything you have in the blink of an eye.[9]

Whoever loves money never has money enough; whoever loves wealth is never satisfied with his income. This too is meaningless.
(Ecclesiastes 5:10)[3]

The wealth of the rich is their fortified city;
they imagine it an unscalable wall.
(Proverbs 18:11)[4]

You say, "I am rich; I have acquired wealth and do not need a thing." But you do not realize that you are wretched, pitiful, poor, blind and naked.
(Revelation 3:17)[5]

Do not be overawed when a man grows rich, when the splendor of his house increases; for he will take nothing with him when he dies.
(Psalm 49:16-17)[6]

Naked I came from my mother's womb, and naked I will depart.
(Job 1:20)[7]

Though your riches increase, do not set your heart on them.
(Psalm 62:10)[8]

Cast but a glance at riches, and they are gone, for they will surely sprout wings and fly off to the sky like an eagle.
(Proverbs 23:5)[9]

Finally, because of the many dangers associated with money—the temptations, pitfalls, and snares—Jesus Christ reminds us how hard it is for a rich man to get into heaven.[10] By way of illustration, He points out that it would be easier for a camel (a large animal) to go through a little door in the walled city (the so-called "eye of the needle"), than it would be for a rich man to get into heaven.[11]

God's Guidance

Instead of putting our hope in wealth, scriptures recommend that we put our hope in God.[12] Instead of being rich in terms of money, the Bible recommends that we be rich in good deeds and generosity.[13] Instead of storing up treasures on earth, Jesus Christ recommends that we store up treasures in heaven, where no thief can steal it, and it will not be destroyed.[14] Instead of be-

How hard it is for the rich to enter the kingdom of God.
(Mark 10:23)[10]

It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle
than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God.
(Mark 10:25)[11]

Command those who are rich in this present world not to be arrogant nor to put their hope in wealth, which is so uncertain, but to put their hope in God, who richly provides us with everything for our enjoyment.
(1 Timothy 6:17)[12]

Command them to do good, to be rich in good deeds, and to be generous and willing to share. In this way they will lay up treasure for themselves as a firm foundation for the coming age, so that they may take hold of the life that is truly life.
(1 Timothy 6:18-19)[13]

Sell your possessions and give to the poor. Provide
purses for yourselves that will not wear out,
a treasure in heaven that will not be exhausted,
where no thief comes near and no moth destroys.
(Luke 12:33)[14]

ing rich in terms of how much gold and silver we own, it is better to be rich in terms of wisdom and understanding.[15]

Above all else, as Christians we are to seek righteousness rather than wealth.[16] In the words of Jesus Christ: "But seek first the kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well." [17]

How much better to get wisdom than gold,
to choose understanding rather than silver!
(Proverbs 16:16)[15]

Wealth is worthless in the day of wrath,
but righteousness delivers from death.
(Proverbs 11:4)[16]

But seek first his kingdom and his righteousness,
and all these things will be given to you as well.
(Matthew 6:33)[17]